Disability & Access Planning

Plan around what you need to stay safe, communicate, move, receive support, and use essential equipment—not around a label or diagnosis.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

If danger is immediate: follow official instructions and move to safety. Tell responders about urgent access, communication, medical, or equipment needs.

START WITH YOUR USUAL DAY

Think through each activity you may need to do at home, while leaving, in transit, and at a shelter. Include supports you use sometimes as well as every day.

- ☐ I identified how I receive warnings and communicate if power, internet, speech, hearing, or vision access changes.
- ☐ I planned how I will move through doorways, stairs, smoke, debris, or unfamiliar spaces.
- ☐ I identified any help I want with transfers, positioning, personal care, eating, or drinking.
- ☐ I packed sensory supports and wrote down ways to reduce noise, light, touch, or crowding.
- ☐ I chose cognitive supports, such as a simple sequence, pictures, reminders, familiar items, or a calm guide.

TRANSPORTATION AND SHELTER PROMPTS

- ☐ Ask local emergency management and transportation providers how to request accessible evacuation transportation. What is the backup?
- ☐ Will the ride accommodate the person, mobility device, support person, service animal, and essential supplies together?
- ☐ Which destinations can meet access needs? Confirm entrances, routes, toilets, cots, charging, refrigeration, communication access, and personal assistance.
- ☐ How will the household reconnect if separated? Keep destination and contact information in more than one accessible format.
- ☐ Practice the route and boarding plan without creating risk. Update the plan when needs, equipment, or providers change.

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Do not assume a shelter has the support or equipment you need. Ask the responsible local authority before an emergency, and keep an alternate destination and transportation plan.

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BUILD A SUPPORT NETWORK

Choose people you trust—near home, work, or other regular locations. A network member should agree before being included.

- ☐ Share only the parts of the plan each person needs. Exchange keys or access instructions only if you choose.
- ☐ Agree who will check in, who can assist, and who has a backup role.
- ☐ Show helpers how you prefer to communicate and how to assist with mobility or transfers; do not let anyone guess or improvise unsafe techniques.
- ☐ Practice contacting one another and review the plan at least when information or needs change.

PLAN FOR HEALTH, EQUIPMENT, AND POWER

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Make these plans with the right experts. Discuss medical contingencies with relevant clinicians; equipment operation and backup power with the supplier or manufacturer; outage programs with the utility; and evacuation, shelter, and emergency-power options with local authorities. This handout does not establish safe device runtimes, battery sizes, medication changes, or clinical instructions.

MEDICATIONS AND REFRIGERATION

- ☐ Keep a current list of medication names, doses, schedules, allergies, prescriber, and pharmacy.
- ☐ Ask the prescriber and pharmacist what to do if a dose, refill, evacuation, contamination, or temperature control is disrupted.
- ☐ For each refrigerated item, get product-specific storage and outage instructions from the pharmacist, clinician, or manufacturer.
- ☐ Use a cooler or discard a product only according to verified product-specific instructions. Do not guess from appearance or a general time limit.
- ☐ Plan how medicines and supplies will travel with you, within required temperature limits and legal requirements.

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DURABLE MEDICAL EQUIPMENT AND ELECTRICITY

Include mobility, breathing, communication, monitoring, transfer, feeding, and other equipment you rely on.

- ☐ Record the exact equipment name, model, serial number, supplier, and support number.
- ☐ Ask the supplier or manufacturer for written shutdown, transport, storage, charging, and backup instructions for the exact model.
- ☐ Ask the clinician for a written contingency plan if equipment is unavailable, damaged, or loses power.
- ☐ Identify compatible backup equipment and power sources. Have a qualified provider confirm connections, ventilation, capacity, maintenance, and safe location.
- ☐ Register for any applicable utility or local emergency program, but do not treat registration as a guarantee of priority restoration or evacuation help.
- ☐ Test and maintain batteries or backup systems only as directed. Never use a fuel-burning generator indoors, in a garage, or near openings.

SERVICE ANIMALS

- ☐ Plan for the animal to remain with its handler during transportation and sheltering; ask local authorities about accessible arrangements.
- ☐ Pack food, water, medicines, bowls, waste supplies, leash or harness, identification, and veterinary information.
- ☐ Identify alternate handlers and care options if the handler cannot provide care.
- ☐ Do not separate, distract, feed, or handle a service animal without the handler's permission.

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PORTABLE SUPPORT-INFORMATION WORKSHEET

Complete only the fields you choose. Use your own words. This is not a requirement for receiving help.

My name or the name I want used: _____

Date reviewed: _____ **Preferred language:** _____

How I communicate best: _____

How to provide information to me (plain words, large print, writing, interpreter, extra time, other):

_____

What helps me understand, remember, or stay regulated:

_____

Mobility, guiding, positioning, or transfer assistance I want:

_____

Do not move or assist me this way: _____

Essential equipment and where it travels with me:

_____

Equipment supplier / support contact: _____

Power, charging, or refrigeration plan: _____

Medications or health information I choose to share:

_____

Service animal support or supplies: _____

Sensory, food, personal-care, or other support needs:

_____

People I authorize helpers to contact:

1. _____ Relationship/role: _____

Phone / other contact: _____

2. _____ Relationship/role: _____

Phone / other contact: _____

Where to find my separate clinical and equipment instructions:

_____

Other information I choose to share: _____

_____

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PROTECT THIS INFORMATION

- ☐ Include only information you want another person to see; leave any field blank.
- ☐ Keep paper copies in a closed, water-resistant holder. Do not display sensitive details on the outside of a bag.
- ☐ Protect digital copies with device access controls and secure sharing. Avoid public links or unencrypted messages for sensitive records.
- ☐ Give copies only to people you choose. Retrieve old copies and update or destroy them securely when information changes.
- ☐ Carry essential instructions, but consider keeping detailed records separately with a trusted contact or in protected storage.

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ESSENTIAL INSTRUCTIONS TO COPY AND CARRY

Written instructions should be specific to you and the exact product or support. Ask the appropriate clinician, pharmacist, supplier, or manufacturer to verify them.

- ☐ Current medication list, allergies, prescriber, pharmacy, and verified missed-dose or disruption instructions
- ☐ Care, communication, behavior-support, mobility, transfer, positioning, or personal-assistance instructions you choose to share
- ☐ Equipment model information and verified setup, shutdown, transport, cleaning, charging, and backup instructions
- ☐ Verified refrigeration requirements and what to do after a temperature excursion
- ☐ Emergency contacts, support-network roles, insurance details, and copies of identification you choose to carry
- ☐ Advance directives or other legal documents, if applicable, stored and shared according to your wishes and local law

BEFORE YOU CALL THE PLAN READY

- ☐ I can reach alerts, plans, and contacts in the formats I use.
- ☐ My primary and backup transportation plans address my access needs.
- ☐ My likely destinations can support me, my equipment, and my service animal.
- ☐ My network knows its roles and has practiced the plan.
- ☐ My medication, refrigeration, equipment, and power contingencies were verified by the relevant experts.
- ☐ My go-bag contains the supplies and copies of instructions I chose to carry.
- ☐ My portable worksheet is current, protected, and shared only as I choose.

RELATED START HERE HANDOUTS

Continue with STH-001 — Emergency Preparedness Quick Start, STH-002 — Build a Two-Week Preparedness Kit, STH-003 — Know Your Local Hazards, and STH-007 — Annual Binder & Kit Review.

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SOURCES

Sources and further planning tools

U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Ready.gov, “Individuals with Disabilities”.

U.S. Department of Justice, ADA.gov, “Emergency Planning”.

U.S. Food and Drug Administration, “Emergency Power Planning Checklist”.

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Administration for Strategic Preparedness and Response, HHS emPOWER Program.

Accessed 2026-09-25.